



Minnehaha United Methodist Church

A Reconciling Congregation
We Seek. We Serve. We Celebrate.

Welcome Friends!

We welcome you to worship wherever you may be in your faith's journey. We strive to live in the way of Jesus Christ, sharing God's love on a daily basis regardless of race, sexual orientation or faith history.

We livestream our worship services, and you may end up in view of the camera at any point in the service.

Worship Personnel

Rev. Becky Sechrist, *Pastor*;
Rev. Jean Elliott, *Director of Children, Youth, & Their Families*;
Alex Rack, *Choir Director*;
Anders Nelson, *Organist*;
Tim Siefkes, *Band Leader*;
Nicholas and Patience Sabah, *Communion Stewards*

Minnehaha United Methodist Church acknowledges that we gather on the traditional, ancestral, and contemporary land of Dakota People.

Attendance

We are delighted you are here! We invite you to "sign the welcome pad" electronically.

If you point your camera phone at the QR code, it will take you to a Google form where you can enter your information.



Offering

For our offering, you can also give electronically through the PayPal account online, or by using this QR Code (which takes you to our PayPal account).



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December 24 2023 4:00 p.m.

* Please rise in body or spirit

Gathering Music

Matt Hughes, *vocals*

The Brightest Star

©2004 Chris Isaak; C Isaak Music Pub Comp (ASCAP)

Welcome

Lighting of the Advent Wreath Trevor, Kayla, Rylan, Parker, & Kyler Hicks

(by Rev. Sarah (Are) Speed; A Sanctified Art LLC; sanctifiedart.org)

Leader: How does a weary world hold onto hope?

People: **By telling stories of hope, and planting seeds in the winter that will bloom in the spring.**

(Light the candle of hope)

Leader: How does a weary world practice peace?

People: **By saying sorry when we need to and choosing grace over hate.**

(Light the candle of peace)

Leader: How does a weary world spread joy?

People: **By dancing and throwing parties and showing up for our community.**

(Light the candle of joy)

Leader: How does a weary world practice love?

People: **By advocating for justice and saving a place at the table.**

(Light the candle of love)

Leader: How does a weary world shine a light into our bleakest night?

People: **We do all these things with God's help. For tonight, a child is born in Bethlehem. Tonight, we light the Christ candle.**

(Light the Christ candle)

Leader: Tonight, Christ draws near. Tonight, we are not alone.

People: **God is near. Love has drawn close. Rejoice! For God loves this weary world.**

*Opening Song

O Come, All Ye Faithful #234 vv. 1-4

The United Methodist Hymnal (red)

John F. Wade (ca. 1743)

in v.2 feel free to sing "Maker" instead of "Father"

Christmas Prayer

(by Rev. Sarah (Are) Speed; A Sanctified Art LLC; sanctifiedart.org)

Loving God, we have heard this story before – the story of a star in the sky and a baby who was laid in a manger. We have heard this story before – passed down in hopeful whispers through the generations. So this night, as we lean our hearts and our ears closer to you, we ask that you would make room in our souls to hear this story again.

Make room in us for awe.

Make room in us for wonder.

(prayer continues on next page)

Make room in us for heartache and compassion.

Make room in our hearts for you.

Pull us into the narrative, that we might hear the truths in this ancient Word as if it were the first time. For we know that you are still speaking. So speak to us again this night. We are listening. We are already making room. Amen.

Special Music

Rosa Gaona, vocals

©1984 Mark Lowry, Buddy Greene; Curb Word Music, Rufus Music (ASCAP)

Mary Did You Know?

This song is meaningful in the ways it speaks to us—not just about Jesus as a baby, but in all that Jesus meant throughout his life. While the lyrics are repetitive, we do suppose Mary was quite aware of the importance of bearing this child. We hear this question being asked as a rhetorical framework for the song.

Reading

Isaiah 9:2, 6-7

Trevor Hicks

***Hymn**

The United Methodist Hymnal (red)

He Is Born #228

Harm. © 1989 The United Methodist Publishing House

Children's Message

Jean Elliott

Reading

Luke 2:1-7

Hymn

The United Methodist Hymnal (red)

Away in a Manger #217

James R. Murray (1887)

Reading

Luke 2:8-20

Hymn

The United Methodist Hymnal (red)

Angels We Have Heard on High #238

Harm. © 1964 Abingdon Press

Sermon

"We Make Room"

Rev. Becky Sechrist

Reading

Psalm 98

Hymn

The United Methodist Hymnal (red)

Joy to the World #246

Isaac Watts (1719) G. F. Handel (1741)

Offering of Gifts and Tithes

Special Music

Go Tell it on the Mountain

trad. Spiritual

Prayer of Dedication

May these gifts of time, talent, and treasure proclaim your saving action in Jesus Christ. Through our offerings, empower this church to share the good news we have seen and heard. Equip us to sing with angels and run with shepherds. Fill us with your peace, that we may live more fully as peacemakers. Expand the horizons of our understanding and expectation, that we may move with confidence into these wider arenas where you call us to serve. Amen.

Hymn

The United Methodist Hymnal (red)

Silent Night #239 (with flashlights)

Joseph Mohr, Franz Gruber (1818)

Benediction

Traveling Music

Julie Darlington, vocals

Mary's Boy Child

©1956 Jester Hairston; Great Gifts of Heritage (ASCAP)

Today's Musicians:

Zobeida Bonilla - acoustic guitar

Satchel Bruna - drums

Kitty Campbell - bass, vocals

Julie Darlington - vocals

Robert Everest - guitar, vocals

Rosa Gaona - vocals

Matt Hughes - electric guitar, vocals

Tim Siefkes - keyboards



Notes from the artist (Hannah Garrity) on "Surrogacy"

Dr. Christena Cleveland published a book in 2023 called, *God is a Black Woman*. In it, she shares her powerful testimony describing her journey to meet the Black Madonnas carved centuries ago from lava rock. This resonates with my lifelong yearning for Mother God. Male language for God has always been a wall to my ability to connect in worship. Now, it is a wall that I break through every week—changing words, rewriting liturgy in the moment, saying “Mother” where “Father” is printed, trying “Lady” where “Lord” is printed. In this case, “Yahweh” is actually best. Who are we to squash God into patriarchy so perpetually? But when someone else joins me in this necessary work, that is when the barrier is removed. I hear it sometimes: “She,” “Mother.” Almost always, the liturgist feels the need to explain themselves. In liturgy discussion, gaslighting is common. “We should be more inclusive.” All of a sudden? Recently, I was standing at The Dwelling at Richmond Hill. The former slave quarters are open and offered for visitation. After our tour, the idea that one should remove their shoes before entering this holy haven came up. Our tour group was all white people and we discussed this idea from a theoretical

standpoint. But earlier, before we entered, I felt it. I was holding a seltzer water can from lunch and felt incredibly rude entering the space with it, so, without understanding, I backtracked and placed my purse and the can outside. I knew not why. After the tour, in our discussion about shoes, our white tour guide mentioned that Black members of the staff felt a great reverence, a holy presence at The Dwelling. The space held the presence of God; it was like entering a sanctuary. I remember the same feeling when I was young, touring the slave quarters at Monticello. But now, listening to the Richmond Hill staff testimony, I understood these spaces in a new way, with a reverence for the God-like presence of the Black mother in the depths of oppression. “Listen to Black women.” This cry has become a mantra over the last few years. I saw in that moment what Cleveland so eloquently explains in her book. In the pigmentocracy we inhabit, the Black mother is the closest figure to God, and “whitemalegod” is the very farthest. He promotes oppression; She is the savior of the most oppressed. And so I listen. In this painting, Black Mother God has asked her daughter Mary to hold the role of surrogate for the pregnancy of infant Creator. Mary has carried the child to term. She has given birth. God embraces Mary as well as the Holy Infant in gratitude. For without Mary’s surrogacy, the incarnation could not be. —**Hannah Garrity**

WELCOME TO ALL VISITING THIS CHRISTMAS EVE!

We're so glad you're here. If you're seeking a church that feels like "home," we hope you'll consider Minnehaha United Methodist Church. We're a thriving multi-generational, multi-cultural congregation. Our Christian faith drives us to take action in our neighborhood through local missions, activism, and sharing the unconditional love of God with our neighbors. We make good things happen here.

We think you'll find ours a community that has a lot to offer:

- A place where **everyone is welcome**
- Faith development in a **positive, non-judgmental** way
- **Meaningful worship** with varied music styles at 9:30 a.m. and a monthly Taize service (3rd Friday of the month)
- **Dynamic children & youth programs** with support for parents
- Lots of opportunities for **service to others**
- The opportunity for close, **life-long friendships**

To find out more, visit our website (www.minnehaha.org) or contact our pastor, Becky Sechrist (becky@minnehaha.org). Thank you for your visit. We hope you'll come back soon.

WINTER STUDIES

- Starting January 7, the Sunday morning Adult Faith Formation class (10:45 a.m.) will be exploring the historical figure of Jesus. A video series created by Professor Bart Erhmann, controversial for his journey from being an evangelical Christian to an atheist, this series focuses on the historical context of Jesus rather than any particular belief about who Jesus is. Conversation in the class will add our own perspectives and beliefs.
- Starting January 8, An Invitation to the Old Testament study will begin on Monday evenings from 6:30-8:00 p.m. at the church. The class will go through March 11. If you are interested in being part of the class, contact Pastor Becky Sechrist to get a book with the readings that we will be utilizing prior to each week.

POINSETTIAS THIS CHRISTMAS EVE ARE GIVEN BY:

Kimberly Beck in memory of Dinah Amundrud and Roger Beck
Marshall & Margaret Cook in memory of their parents
Bob & Diane Enge in honor and memory of our parents Arlyne & Manny Forsberg and Bud & Dorene Enge
Sarah Hicks in memory of loved ones
Char & Craig Johnson in memory of loved ones who have passed and in honor of Alicia & Rachel Johnson
Peter & Sue Johnson in celebration of family
Margaret Rawson in celebration of CRAFTS (Calista, Ryne, Amy, Francesca, Tyler, and Shane)
Pat Roth in memory of Joan Ellison and Bob & Barb Ellison
James Shetler in memory of brothers Jerry and Richard

ALTAR FLOWERS

are given today in honor of
Jan Hougen's 90th
birthday tomorrow with
love from her family.
Happy birthday Jan!